

CONTENT ANALYSIS OF PUBLICLY VISIBLE ASSESSMENT POLICY DISCOURSES IN UNIVERSITIES

Ryan Surace¹, Joanna Tai², Claire Palermo³, Judi Porter¹

¹ Deakin University, School of Exercise and Nutrition Sciences

² Deakin University – Centre for Research in Assessment and Digital Learning

³ Monash University, Faculty of Medicine, Nursing and Health Sciences

Email: ryan.surace@deakin.edu.au

INTRODUCTION

Assessment is vital in education as it promotes learning and ensures health professional graduates are safe and ready for professional practice. [1] Assessment in higher education sits at the intersection of learning, professional judgement, and accountability, making it an inherently complex endeavour. Assessment is widely assumed to be systematic and coherent although practices often evolve through messy, context-dependent processes. [2] Assessment design and implementation in higher education is continually shaped by many different factors including technology, government regulations, engagement of students in their learning, and policy. [3,4] Furthermore, there is ongoing friction between policies created within higher education and the specific requirements of health professions education programs with the relationship of policy and directives on practice remaining unclear. [5,6] Therefore, this paper responds to the following research question – what directions do university assessment policies currently set for practice?

METHODS

Content analysis, underpinned by the grand theory of interpretivism, was employed using a combination of qualitative and quantitative methods and both deductive and inductive analytical approaches to understand the directions policy discourse may have on assessment practice. Universities hosting accredited nutrition and dietetic programs were the unit of analysis, ensuring the inclusion of universities with direct experience in navigating and implementing policy within regulated education contexts. A keyword search ('assessment') in the policy library of individual institution websites from 20 highly ranked universities in Australia and New Zealand was conducted. A data extraction spreadsheet was generated to capture relevant and prominent features of the documents. A coding framework and codebook were also created, with dominant features from the assessment discourse initially coded. The coding framework evolved iteratively and categories developed further to answer the research question.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Among the 20 universities, 18 (90%) were located in Australia, and the remaining 2 (10%) in New Zealand. The majority (n = 18, 90%) were ranked in the top 500 universities worldwide according to the Times Higher

Education World University Rankings. Across the 31 documents the majority (n = 29, 94%) were labelled as either 'policy' or procedure'. Four categories relating to the direction assessment policy discourse may set for practice were uncovered from the 31 documents: assessment design, purpose, quality improvement and voice, and choice. There was limited content focused on innovative approaches, technological design and practice and student agency, all of which are important in the context of current assessment challenges. Accreditation was a prevailing discourse feature, perhaps indicative of the influence it can have on assessment redevelopment, although the consideration of interest holders in assessment was somewhat limited. There was also sparse discourse references to Generative Artificial Intelligence, although this plausibly is more closely linked to policy timing and reflects a currently cautious approach to new and emerging technologies.

CONCLUSIONS

Assessment policy discourse should balance the desire for consistent practice and legal defensibility with opportunities for providing content focused on transformative practice to help shape how competency and readiness for practice are defined and assured in education training programs. Engaging interest holders in understanding how policy can better support practical challenges may be helpful for future policy development.

REFERENCES

- [1] Boud. *Stud in high educ.* **15 (1)**: 101-111, 1990.
- [2] Margetts et al. *J High Educ Pol Mx.* **46 (3)**: 321-345, 2024.
- [3] Charlton et al. *Assess Eval High Educ.* **47(8)**: 1475-1488, 2022.
- [4] West et al. *Assess Eval High Educ.* **50(3)**: 381-395, 2025.
- [5] Meyer et al. *Higher Educ Quart.* **64(3)**: 331-350, 2010.
- [6] Boud et al. *Assess Eval High Educ.* **31(4)**: 399-413, 2006.